

The Extraction

Genre: Action Thriller

Age Range: 18-25

Characters

AVA (21) - An intelligence asset who has spent months undercover gathering evidence.

NOAH (24) - The operative sent to extract her before her cover is blown.

Runtime: 3-4 Minutes

Difficulty: Intermediate

Scene Description

After months undercover, Ava finally meets the operative sent to rescue her. The problem? She refuses to leave.

NOAH: Ava?

AVA: Took you long enough.

NOAH: Nice to see you too.

AVA: You're late.

NOAH: By three minutes.

AVA: Three minutes is a long time when people are trying to kill you.

NOAH: Fair point.

(Noah checks the hallway.)

NOAH: We need to move.

AVA: Not happening.

NOAH: Excuse me?

AVA: I'm not leaving.

NOAH: That's funny.

AVA: I'm serious.

NOAH: No, you're not.

AVA: Noah—

NOAH: I crossed two borders and nearly got arrested getting here.

AVA: Congratulations.

NOAH: My job is to get you out.

AVA: Then your job just got complicated.

NOAH: Why?

AVA: Because if I leave tonight, twelve people die tomorrow.

(Beat.)

NOAH: What?

AVA: There's a shipment.

NOAH: That's not our concern.

AVA: It becomes our concern when innocent people are involved.

NOAH: Our concern is keeping you alive.

AVA: Mine isn't.

NOAH: That's not how this works.

AVA: Says who?

NOAH: Every rule we've ever been trained to follow.

AVA: Then maybe the rules are wrong.

NOAH: Easy to say when you're not the one responsible.

AVA: Responsible for what?

NOAH: Bringing you home.

(Beat.)

AVA: You don't even know me.

NOAH: I know enough.

AVA: Really?

NOAH: I know you've spent eight months pretending to be someone else.

AVA: That's called undercover work.

NOAH: I know you haven't slept properly in weeks.

AVA: Lucky guess.

NOAH: I know you've convinced yourself you're the only person who can stop this.

AVA: Because I am.

NOAH: That's what everyone says before they get themselves killed.

(Silence.)

AVA: You're afraid.

NOAH: Of course I'm afraid.

AVA: Not for yourself.

NOAH: Don't do that.

AVA: Do what?

NOAH: Act like you can read people.

AVA: I don't have to read you.

NOAH: Ava—

AVA: You're carrying guilt.

(Noah looks away.)

AVA: Somebody didn't make it out, did they?

(Beat.)

NOAH: That's not your business.

AVA: It is now.

NOAH: This mission isn't about me.

AVA: Then why are you arguing so hard?

NOAH: Because I am tired of watching good people decide they're expendable.

(Silence.)

AVA: That's not what this is.

NOAH: Then what is it?

AVA: Choice.

NOAH: Choice?

AVA: For months, everyone else decided what mattered.

NOAH: Ava—

AVA: Tonight, I decide.

NOAH: And if you're wrong?

AVA: Then I live with it.

NOAH: That's easy to say.

AVA: No.

(Beat.)

AVA: It's terrifying.

NOAH: Good.

AVA: Good?

NOAH: Fear means you're taking it seriously.

(Ava smiles slightly.)

AVA: Somebody told me that once.

NOAH: Smart person.

AVA: Not really.

(Distant footsteps echo.)

NOAH: We don't have much time.

AVA: Then make a choice.

NOAH: You're impossible.

AVA: I've been called worse.

NOAH: If we stay, everything changes.

AVA: I know.

NOAH: This is not the mission.

AVA: Maybe it's a better one.

(Beat.)

NOAH: I hate that you're making sense.

AVA: So that's a yes?

(Noah sighs.)

NOAH: That's a "we're both going to regret this."

AVA: I'll take it.

NOAH: What's the plan?

(Ava grabs a folder.)

AVA: Now you're asking the right question.

BLACKOUT

Ending Beat:

Noah abandons the original mission and chooses to help Ava stop the attack, accepting that doing the right thing sometimes means breaking the rules.